

- Import your video footage from your camera
- Edit, arrange and beautify (add music, special effects, etc) your video footage
- Convert your work into DVD compatible video
- Create a layout (menus) for your DVD
- Burn your DVD

Let me mention at the outset that following the guidelines in this article might turn out easier on Fedora than on other GNU/Linux distros, but definitely won't be impossible. For Fedora users, the Livna repository (which has recently been merged with RPMFusion) will be very handy, and you should first add the repository by clicking on all the right places at rpmfusion.org/Configuration. Add both the free and non-free repositories.

Once this is done, you can install any required software for your home DVD with *Yum*.

Importing video footage

The way to import video footage would depend largely on the equipment that you have. If you use a digital (still) camera to capture your video, then the process is as simple as attaching your camera to your Linux box via a USB cable and copying the files off it. Personally, I use a card reader.

If you use a tape-based video camera, which is a little dated (like the one I have), then you are probably going to need some extra hardware on your machine. I have a very cheap PCI TV card on my machine that, apart from having the RF input for the TV signal, also has a Composite and an S-Video input. These are just different standards for analogue video, and S-Video is supposed to give somewhat better video quality than Composite. For most of us, the difference will be imperceptible.

Using an appropriate cable, connect the output of your video camera to the input of your TV card. At this point you are ready to transfer the footage to your

hard disk. I use *mencoder*, brother of MPlayer, and in my mind an underrated and underused piece of software. You should definitely have these two gems installed on your machine. Do that with:

```
yum -y install mplayer mencoder
```

You are probably going to have *Yum* install a whole lot of other dependencies with it as well, so don't panic!

Now there are two ways in which we could use *mencoder* to import the video. One would be to import using real-time encoding to some popular video format like Xvid, or we could import raw footage, that is, unencoded video format. An encoding algorithm would, of course, take much less space than raw footage, but it would also result in some loss of quality.

I prefer to import raw video and work on it. That's because we will eventually have to encode the edited movie to the particular format that DVD video uses, and encoding twice will result in quality that you might not be too happy with. However, you could also just take the video you have shot and convert it into an encoded format like Xvid without any editing. (This could be done if you have a DVD player that also supports DivX file formats and you are sure that you don't have any unnecessary footage—or also if you are plain lazy!)

Here are a couple of variations on the same theme. Both of these would grab video coming from the TV card and encode it on-the-fly to a specified format.

```
mencoder -of avi -tv driver=v4l: \
input=1:device=/dev/video0:forceaudio: \
norm=NTSC:width=640:height=480 \
-ovc lavc -lavcopts vcodec=mpeg4: \
vbitrate=2000 -oac mp3lame -lameopts cbr: \
br=224 -o output.avi tv://
```

```
mencoder -of avi -tv driver=v4l:input=1: \
device=/dev/video0:forceaudio:norm=PAL: \
width=640:height=480 -ovc xvid -xvidencopts \
```

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